Strength in Uncertainty:
A Safe Space for Dreamers

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DACA Students & Uncertainty

50% drop in new enrollments of low-income undocumented students in UC and CSU

Decline in overall enrollment by 30% (2018-2023)

Challenges faced by DACA Recipients

Anxiety, career uncertainty, discrimination

Family separation fears (Guadalupe, 2023)

Limited legal protections

Psychological & Emotional Impact

Stress & Mental Health Risks

- Impaired cognitive function (memory, impulse control)
- Hypervigilance & fear of deportation
- Changing administrations affecting DACA policies
- Financial aid & FAFSA concerns

"Fighting for a better future for all."

F. M.

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Group Therapy as a Solution

Why Group Therapy?

- Universality – Knowing they are not alone
- Cohesion – Building a sense of belonging
- Emotional regulation & resilience-building

Therapy Group

Goal: Build emotional resilience, reduce anxiety, and prepare for career/educational futures.

Structure: 12-week, close group, with weekly 90-minute sessions.

Participants: DACA recipients aged 19–26, committed to attending all sessions.

Outcome: Reduce anxiety by 20% (measured by GAD-7) and develop individualized career/educational plans.

GAD-7

GAD-7 ANXIETY

Over the last two weeks, how often have you been bothered by the following problems?	Not at all	Several days	More than half the days	Nearly every day
1. Feeling nervous, anxious, or on edge	0	1	2	3
2. Not being able to stop or control worrying	0	1	2	3
3. Worrying too much about different things	0	1	2	3
4. Trouble relaxing	0	1	2	3
5. Being so restless that it is hard to sit still	0	1	2	3
6. Becoming easily annoyed or irritable	0	1	2	3
7. Feeling afraid, as if something awful might happen	0	1	2	3

Column Totals _____ + _____ + _____ + _____ =

Total Score _____

Scoring GAD-7 Anxiety Severity

This is calculated by assigning scores of 0, 1, 2, and 3 to the response categories, respectively, of "not at all," "several days," "more than half the days," and "nearly every day."
GAD-7 total score for the seven items ranges from 0 to 21.

0–4: minimal anxiety

5–9: mild anxiety

10–14: moderate anxiety

15–21: severe anxiety

Recruitment and Screening

Recruitment: Flyers at NDNU, College of San Mateo, Cañada College, and One Life Counseling Services.

Screening: Individual interviews to assess fit, commitment, and challenges.

Exclusion Criteria: Active psychosis, substance dependence, high self-harm risk, severe social anxiety.

Group Dynamics and Logistics

Composition: 6–12 participants with diverse backgrounds and attachment styles.

Logistics: Wednesdays, 6:00–7:30 PM, at NDNU

Benefits: Safe space for vulnerability, peer support, and practical tools for future success.

Key Challenges in Group Therapy

Cultural Considerations & Ethical Issues

- Language barriers
- Trust & fear of infiltration (ensuring safety)

Managing Groups Dynamics

- Conflicts as opportunities for growth
- Addressing trauma while maintaining emotional regulation

Psychological & Identity Integration

Theoretical Frameworks

Akhtar's (1999) 4 Stages of Immigrant Identity:

- Ambivalence (Love vs. Hate)
- Cultural Distance vs. Closeness
- Past vs. Future vs. Present Focus
- Integration of 'We-ness'

Psychodynamic Perspective

Mourning & Immigration

- Loss of culture, language, familiar surroundings

"We have sacrificed a lot... fighting for our dreams."

A.G.

Curriculum

Session 1	**Building Trust and Safety**	Establish group rules and safety guidelines. Provide participants with a consent form and privacy notice to review and sign. Create a welcoming and supportive environment. Administer Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7 Scale (GAD-7) Encourage participants to start sharing about themselves
Session 2	**Understanding Anxiety and Its Effects**	Help participants understand anxiety, recognize its symptoms, and learn coping strategies for managing anxiety related to moving to a new country.
Session 3	**Exploring Coping Strategies**	Identify, understand, and practice effective coping strategies to manage stress, anxiety, and challenges related to their experiences as DACA recipients.
Session 4	**Sharing Personal Challenges**	Provide a safe space for DACA recipients to share challenges related to immigration status, education, career, and personal life.
Session 5	**Uncertainty and Resilience**	Provide participants with strategies to manage uncertainty related to immigration status and current socio-political events while fostering resilience.
Session 6	**Navigating Systemic Barriers**	Address systemic challenges and explore strategies for advocacy and self-empowerment.

Curriculum

Session 7	**Career Readiness**	Help participants identify strengths and weaknesses in career readiness, explore essential life skills, and create a plan to develop skills like career searching, mentorship, and practical application.
Session 8	**Building Support Networks, Strengthening Social Support**	Share thoughts and feelings about existing and new support groups and local resources. Discuss experiences with and benefits of specific support networks.
Session 9	**Goal Setting and Empowerment**	Provide participants with effective goal-setting strategies to enhance personal empowerment and facilitate academic, professional, and personal progress.
Session 10	**Reflecting on Growth and Building Future Resilience**	Help participants reflect on personal growth, prepare for transitions, and develop strategies for maintaining resilience beyond the group.
Session 11	**Integrating skills and creating a vision board**	Identifying and applying coping skills, goals, change strategies, and support networks into a visual and inspiring vision board.
Session 12	**Group closure and sharing final reflection**	Gain a sense of closure, accomplishment, and direction from the 12 weeks of sessions. Administer Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7 Scale (GAD-7) Celebrate the cohesion and collaboration that has been established.

Example of a Session

Session 4 Sharing Personal Challenges

Objective
P**rovide a safe space** for recipients to **share challenges related to immigration status, education, career, and personal life**.

A**ctivities**
C**heck-in Question**: “What's one thing you're bringing to the group today?"
G**rounding Exercise**: Brief breathing or mindfulness moment to center participants.

Conclusion
Therapist reflects on the **importance of acknowledging challenges and the strength participants have shown.**
Each participant **shares one takeaway** from the discussion.
P**review of the next session’**s focus on resilience and coping strategies.

Business and Marketing Plans

Flyers and Printed Promotion

- Student center of NDNU, CSM, Cañada College
- Counseling organizations One Life and StarVista
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Email and Newsletter

- University mailing lists
- Campus diversity clubs or support offices

Using Trusted Networks for Outreach

- Universities, counseling services, nonprofits

Branding & Marketing Considerations

Challenges of Promoting a DACA Support Group

- Fear of exposure
- Political sensitivity

Discreet Branding & Messaging Strategies

- Neutral group names
- Focus on emotional resilience & stress management

Using Trusted Networks for Outreach

- Universities, counseling services, nonprofits

Budget Estimates

Therapist Costs: $2,100

Supplies: $800

Grant request: $3000

To comfortably sustain the group and account for any unforeseen costs, we requested $3,000 in funding.

Role Play

Therapist

Name: Maxx

Position: Marriage and Family Trainee

School: Notre Dame de Namur

Role Play Vignettes

Sofia`	Nando	Maya
22 years old DACA recipient Recent graduate from San Francisco State University	19 years old DACA recipient Cañada College Student	21 years old DACA recipient San Francisco State University Student
Determined: Earned a degree, built a strong resume, and persists despite rejections. **Faces Systemic Barrier**s: Cannot find a job in her career due to her immigration status. **Needs Advocacy Skills**: Seeks tools to confidently explain her DACA status in job interviews. **Emotional Struggles:** Feels depressed, frustrated, exhausted, and questions her efforts. **Lacks Guidance**: Unsure where to find DACA-friendly employers and resources. **Desires Solutions**: Wants strategies to improve her job search and build a support network.	**Hardworking & Ambitious**: Earned top grades in Highschool and worked after school tirelessly to pursue a better future. **Faces Systemic Barriers**: Excluded from federal aid and many scholarships due to his immigration status. **Family Sacrifices**: Parents work exhausting manual labor jobs to support Nando and his sisters. **Emotional Struggles**: Feels stuck and worthless about the uncertainty of his future as a DACA recipient.	**Resilient and Positive**: She's a good student, and is very family oriented. **Faces Systemic Barriers**: Bias and discrimination when disclosing her DACA status. **Family Sacrifices**: Raised by a single mother who is now in Mexico with her grandmother. **Emotional Struggles:** Feels anxious about her migration status. **Resilience**: Pushes through challenges, like forcing herself to go for a run despite feeling unmotivated.

Expected Outcomes & Impact

By the End of the 12-Week Program

- 20% reduction in anxiety (self-reported)
- Mastery of at least 3 coping strategies
- Completion of an individualized career/education plan

Long-Term Benefits

- Increased sense of community & empowerment
- Improved emotional regulation

Q&A

¡GRACIAS!

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THANK YOU!